registrar to take action if he had not.[6] Based on this complaint, the registrar instructed the district registrar to inquire into it.[7] Delay in submission would have meant inquiries and fines—a situation SSNCo could scarcely afford at this time. It seems that Swadeshi company was able to avoid such an unpleasant situation. K.R. Guruswami Aiyar had claimed, on 1 April, in his interview with the governor that the company had indeed filed the balance sheet.[8]

When the SSNCo's directors met on 26 January 1908, they had resolved to hold the annual general meeting for 1908 on 21 March.[9] The hectic months from late December 1907 to March 1908 had however given them little breathing space. Even as the preparations were on, the scheduled meeting of the directors to prepare and pass the annual report for submission to the general body could not be held 'owing to the panic in the town subsequent to the 13th instant', an obvious reference to the Tirunelveli 'Riots'. It was only on 30 March, nearly three weeks later, that the directors could even meet. A new date—26 June—was now decided upon for the annual meeting. In addition to all that had happened, the statutory necessity to audit accounts for the period after December 1907 had also come up.[10]

On 2 April 1908, the directors met again—the frequent meetings no doubt indicate the challenges facing the company. It was at this meeting that a proposal for issuing 6 per cent debentures and doubling the share capital was first broached. The expansion of the fleet with the acquisition of another steamship and a steam launch was also discussed.[11] Possibly the company believed that the political storm had passed, and now its business would flourish unhindered.

VOC Resigns

An outcome of the turmoil within SSNCo was VOC's formal resignation from the company. One can scarcely imagine the distress that this must have caused him. In June 1908, while still an undertrial prisoner in Palayamkottai jail, VOC resigned from his agent-ship. The timing is